LIONSCRAFT

A PRIMER

On / Off-Ramps and the gates of a financial system.

How money enters and leaves the stablecoin economy — and why whoever owns the gate owns the relationship.

A regulated on-switch between two financial systems.

ON-RAMP

Fiat → Crypto

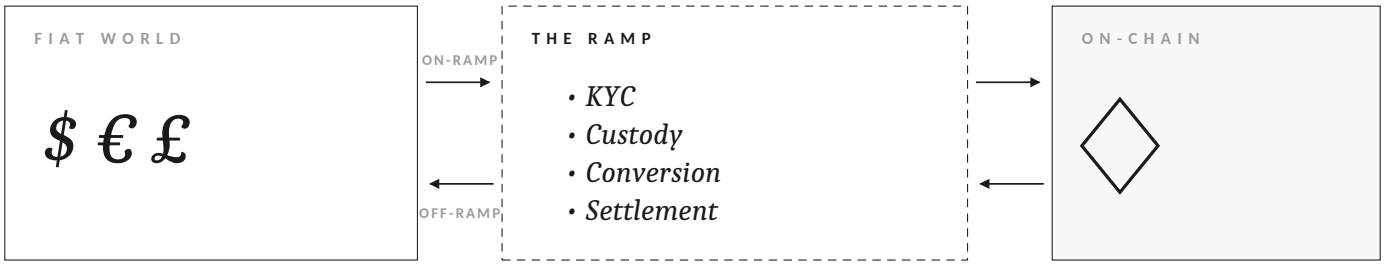
The process of converting FIAT (like USD or EUR) into cryptocurrency to enter the digital market.

OFF-RAMP

Crypto → Fiat

The process of selling cryptocurrency to receive FIAT back into a traditional bank account.

THE SHAPE OF IT



Banks · cards · ACH · SEPA · wires

Licensed institutions translate between two settlement systems.

Wallets · stablecoins · L1s & L2s

Ramps are the only place most users touch crypto.

Adoption, conversion, and trust all bottleneck through the ramp. A bad first transaction is a permanent churn event.

~ 95%	$1.4T	30-40%
OF RETAIL USERS	ANNUAL RAMP VOLUME	KYC DROP-OFF
arrive via a fiat ramp	*est. across all providers*	*on first-time users*

THREE AUDIENCES, THREE JOBS

Retail

Buy a token in under 60 seconds with a card or bank transfer.

Apps

Embed funding into wallets, games, NFT mints — without holding a money licence.

Institutions

Move treasury between USD and stablecoins for payments & FX.

From tap to wallet, in seven steps.

A typical on-ramp transaction routes through three stages — onboarding, settlement, on-chain — collapsing seven discrete steps into roughly a minute of wall-clock time.

STAGE I
ONBOARDING

01 Pick amount & asset
Quote locked ~30s
— *T+0s* Quote

02 KYC verification
First time only
— *~60s* KYC complete

STAGE II
SETTLEMENT

03 Funding + wallet addr.
Card / ACH / SEPA
— *~90s* Pay submitted

04 Fiat charge clears
Provider risk · T+1–2
— *3DS auth* Charge clears

05 Conversion on market
OTC / book / DEX
— *+~5s* Trade filled

STAGE III
ON-CHAIN & AFTER

06 On-chain payout
Sol <1s · BTC ~10m
— *+chain time* Funds in wallet

07 Recon & reporting
Receipts · webhooks
— *async* Receipts sent

Off-ramps reverse the same chain.

KEY PLAYERS

No single company moves the whole ramp.

A typical transaction touches 5–7 distinct entities, each regulated, each taking a small cut. The "ramp brand" is usually only the front door.

LAYER 01

Ramp / widget

MoonPay · Stripe · Coinbase Onramp · Transak · Ramp Network

Owns the user UI, KYC orchestration, quote, support. Often white-labeled into another app.

LAYER 02

Payment processor

Stripe · Adyen · Checkout · Worldpay · Plaid (ACH)

Pulls fiat from card networks or bank accounts; handles fraud, chargebacks, 3DS.

LAYER 03

Liquidity / exchange

Coinbase Prime · Kraken · Cumberland · B2C2 · DEX aggregators

Provides the actual market — fiat is exchanged for the token at a quoted rate.

LAYER 04

Custody & settlement

Fireblocks · BitGo · Anchorage · Fordefi · self-custody (MPC)

Signs the on-chain transaction; the only point where keys actually move value.

LAYER 05

Blockchain

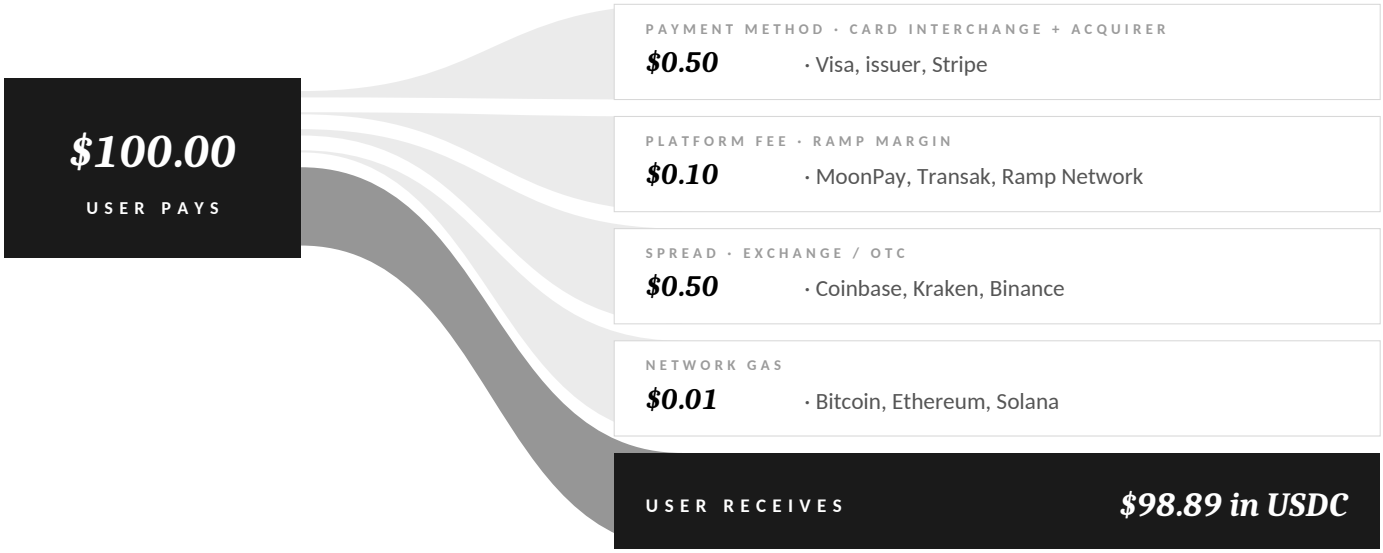
Ethereum · Solana · Base · Arbitrum · Bitcoin · Polygon

The settlement layer. Everything above is how value reaches it.

Four fees stacked. You feel them as one %.

Every ramp transaction pays four toll booths. They apply on the way in and the way out — numbers vary by provider, region, asset, and rail.

> ⚠ **EXAMPLE ONLY — NOT A QUOTE**
> These figures are illustrative. Actual fees depend on provider, payment method, region, asset and rail. Always confirm against a live quote.



FEE TYPE	ON-RAMP	OFF-RAMP	NOTES
Payment method	*0% – 5%*	*0.5% – 2%*	Cards ~3–5%. ACH / SEPA often free or flat-fee.
Platform fee	*0.1% – 1.5%*	*0.1% – 1.5%*	The ramp's own service charge.
Spread	*0.5% – 2.0%*	*0.5% – 2.0%*	Hidden gap between market price and the quote.
Network gas	*$0.01 – $50+*	*$0.01 – $50+*	Paid to the destination chain. Varies by chain and congestion.

Most ramps don't sell crypto. They sell stablecoins.

USDC and USDT are now the dominant ramp output — letting the conversion step be a 1:1 redemption rather than a price trade. That compresses spread and removes volatility risk for the provider.

WITHOUT STABLECOINS

USD → BTC

- Provider must hold price risk during settlement (T+1-2)
- Spread widens to absorb volatility
- Quotes must refresh every ~30s

WITH STABLECOINS

USD → USDC

- Issuer (Circle, Tether) mints 1:1 against fiat reserves
- Effectively a tokenized money-market deposit
- Conversion is bookkeeping, not trading

THE MINT / BURN LOOP



Ramps fail in predictable ways. Plan for them.

CARD DECLINE

Issuing bank blocks crypto MCC

The single biggest cause of failed retail buys. Ramps mitigate by routing across multiple acquirers.

CHARGEBACK

User reverses the card after delivery

Crypto is irreversible; cards aren't. Provider eats the loss. Why card fees are so high.

KYC DROP-OFF

User abandons during ID upload

30–40% of new users. Pre-KYC and tiered limits help; no full fix exists.

WRONG NETWORK

USDC sent to ETH address on Solana

Funds are usually unrecoverable. Good UX forces network selection up-front.

BANK DE-RISKING

Provider loses banking partner

Off-ramps go offline overnight. Why ramps run multiple banking relationships.

TRAVEL RULE

Counterparty info required > threshold

FATF rule for $1k+ transfers. Self-custody addresses can be flagged or blocked.

The European licensing layer.

In Europe, a ramp is regulated infrastructure — not a product feature. MiCAR + PSD2 set the rules; SEPA sets the rails.

MiCAR — CASP authorisation

Any operator running fiat ↔ crypto exchange in the EU needs a CASP (Crypto-Asset Service Provider) licence under MiCAR. National regulators (BaFin, AMF, CNMV…) issue, with passporting across the EU.

PSD2 — payment leg

The fiat side requires PSP, EMI, or full-bank licensing. Many ramps partner rather than hold the licence themselves; some (BVNK, Bitstamp) hold both.

SEPA Instant — the rail

From October 2025, all EU PSPs must support SEPA Instant. That makes near-real-time euro on-ramps possible without card networks — and shifts the cost stack downward.

EUR stablecoin ramps

EURC (Circle), EURCV (Société Générale-FORGE), and from H2 2026 Qivalis become the natural EUR-side ramp targets. USD-only ramps will lose ground in EU consumer flows.

GET IN TOUCH

Let's continue the conversation.



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Ramps are a moving target. Pricing, regulation, and category lines shift quarterly. If you're building, buying, or partnering — happy to dig in.